Children Helped Make the Middle East's Oldest Clay Figures

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Long before anyone invented pottery, people in the Middle East were already shaping clay into tiny figures. **Archaeologists** say more than 150 of these artworks, found across present-day Israel, are likely the region's earliest clay figures. And some were made by children.

The figures date back 11,500 to 15,000 years. They were made by the **Natufians**, hunter-gatherers who lived in the **Fertile Crescent** between 9,500 and 13,000 BCE and were beginning to settle down and move toward farming.

The figures show birds and **hooved** mammals like deer, as well as male and female people. Some still carry traces of **pigment** and dyes. Others carry the ancient fingerprints of their makers. By studying those marks, researchers found that both children and adults helped make the figures.

Clay is not like stone or bone. Earlier Natufian figures were carved from hard materials. Clay needed different skills: shaping soft earth, then baking and hardening it. The findings were published in the journal PLOS One. Laurent Davin of The Hebrew University of Jerusalem said the fingerprints show creativity was shared across generations.

Word Treasure

Archaeologists -- Archaeologists are people who study old things left behind by people long ago to learn how they lived.

Natufians -- The Natufians were a group of people who lived in the Middle East long ago and were starting to settle down and farm.

Fertile Crescent -- The Fertile Crescent is a land in the Middle East where some of the first farming began.

pigment -- A pigment is a colored powder or paste that people use to paint or dye things.

hooved -- Hooved means having hard feet like a deer's, instead of paws or toes.

Background you need

Long ago, before people learned to make pots, they shaped soft clay into small figures of animals and people.

Clay is soft earth that can be shaped by hand and then baked until it turns hard, which is different from carving stone or bone.

People who study the past can learn from the tiny fingerprints left in the clay, because they show who made the figures.

Break it down

WHO: The Natufians, hunter-gatherers in the Fertile Crescent, including children and adults

WHAT: They shaped clay into tiny figures of birds, hooved mammals, and people, likely the region's earliest clay figures

WHERE: Across present-day Israel, in the Middle East

WHY: The fingerprints on the figures show that creativity was shared across generations, with children helping to make them

Why it matters

Seeing that children long ago helped make art shows that your own making and creating matters too, even when you are young.

Test what you remember

1. Who helped make some of the clay figures?

(A) Only artists from France
(B) Only potters in factories
(C) Only kings
(D) Children and adults

2. What did the figures show?

(A) Only cars and trains
(B) Only fish and whales
(C) Only trees and flowers
(D) Birds, hooved mammals like deer, and people

3. Where were the figures found?

(A) In a cave in South America
(B) Across present-day Israel
(C) On the moon
(D) In a mine in Thailand

4. What were earlier Natufian figures carved from?

(A) Soft clay
(B) Glass
(C) Metal
(D) Hard materials like stone or bone

5. How did researchers know children helped make the figures?

(A) By reading a diary
(B) By watching a video
(C) By asking the children
(D) By studying the ancient fingerprints on them

6. How old are the figures?

(A) 11,500 to 15,000 years old
(B) About 1,000 years old
(C) About 500 years old
(D) About 100 years old

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: D 3: B 4: D 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Laurent Davin of The Hebrew University of Jerusalem: The fingerprints show that creativity was shared across generations.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):